

barriers other than those inseparable from gaining access to the internet itself. The only constraint on reproduction and distribution, and the only role for copyright in this domain, should be to give authors control over the integrity of their work and the right to be properly acknowledged and cited."

For countries like India, talent-rich and resource-poor, such concepts have much relevance. But there are roadblocks in their implementation too.

Campaigning persistently for OA

In India, one of the most persistent campaigners for the cause of OA has been the Chennai-based Subbiah Arunachalam ("Call me Arun," as he is quick to say). After ages, we recently got back in touch, and the octogenarian was as feisty as I've long known him to be.

Way back in December 2003, Stevan Harnad (the Hungarian-born cognitive scientist based in Montreal, Canada, who has long been very active globally in the space of open access self-archiving and EPrints) said, "No one on the planet is more closely and deeply identified with the cause of researchers and journals who lack the resources to make their output openly accessible than Professor Arunachalam. We are deeply grateful for his generous collaboration." He called the professor "India's and the developing world's great advocate for open access." (See <http://cogprints.ecs.soton.ac.uk/>.)

Arun is forever circulating texts of various kinds related to the open access campaign. Once he knows you're interested in the subject, you'll get a lot of posts from his keyboard.

He has also been following issues such as open science, and gets into conversations with global leaders on these subjects. He has asked the open science team a few questions like: "How can we speed up the acceptance of the culture of open science and adoption of preprints? What specific steps can scientists, funders and governments take?"



Professor Arunachalam

Arun, even today, is keen to promote open access to knowledge, especially the knowledge generated by academic and other research institutions in India, e.g., CSIR (Council for Scientific & Industrial Research), DST (Department of Science and Technology), DBT (Department of Biotechnology), DRDO (Defence Research & Development Organisation), DAE (Department of Atomic Energy), Department of Space, ICMR (Indian Council of Medical Research) and ICSSR (Indian Council of Social Science Research), think tanks, and industry-related research institutions.

To his mind, the A2K (access to knowledge) movement is not alien or distant from other related campaigns — FOSS (free and open source software), community radio, the right to information, open access, among others.

True, indeed!

In an interview with the Indian Institute of Science, Arun pointed out that some people call him 'Mr Open Access, India', and he sees himself as an advocate of interoperable open access repositories and open science.

Arun explains: "There was resistance in the beginning, but now even journal publishers who opposed OA initially are ready to come on board; however, they also want to retain their profits and are trying to find models [to do so]. Open access is

now an accepted idea. According to a 2013 study funded by the European Commission, more than 50 per cent of what is produced in science and technology is available in the open in some form or the other."

He points out that this has happened "all within the last 20 years." Major funders such as the Wellcome Trust and the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation are supporters of open access.

Why open access?

"If knowledge in the sciences, including social sciences, is locked up in [costly] subscription journals, only those who subscribe to those journals can access it. Unless all the knowledge you need is freely available, your ability to further advance knowledge is limited. If all knowledge is available to all, chances of seeing more knowledge produced are very high. That is the *raison d'être* for open access," says Arun.

He adds that researchers in most so-called developing countries are working "under very difficult conditions, especially with regard to information access."

Internet technologies have the "potential to democratise access to information (and facilitate collaboration)," he says, both for scientific research and rural development. He cites the cases of China and South Korea, which have shown how a country can "lift itself up from a scientific nobody to a world-class performer in a decade or two." Creating a worldwide information commons, through the establishment of interoperable open access repositories for research papers and scientific data, shows the way.

"The best way to help poor nations is to make them self-supporting by strengthening science in those countries. There is no better means to do that than by adopting the public commons approach to information sharing," in his view.